

times past, when generations have accepted generational challenges. Hero Generations like those who defeated fascism in World War II and the victorious countries returned to form the United Nations and the Marshall Plan and to unify Europe and to create the world trading system. Because having walked through that fire, they gained—almost without realising that they were doing so—a capacity for moral authority and long-term vision that they never knew they had in the past. And so when their leaders said, “It is time we steered by the stars and not by the lights of every passing ship”, they said, “You are right”. When they said, “We may have to have higher taxes in order to finance this effort to lift our adversaries from their battlefields from their knees to walk with them into independence and freedom”, they said “Yes, you are right”. When their leaders said, “It may take 50 years for this to work”, they said, “It is okay. We are in this because we are tired of Europe exporting their world wars to the rest of the planet.” We see the need to take a longer term approach and try to come up with a better future. That is the challenge we face now.

Being guided by the lights of every passing ship will not suffice for us any longer. We are one people. We live in

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Session chairperson Aron Purie (left) with Gore

separate nation states. We are proud of our differences, we feel pride in our nations and in our different creed and beliefs. But ultimately we are one people on one planet. Let nobody tell you the solution to the climate crisis is colonising outer space. In the United States, we couldn't even evacuate New Orleans. This is our home. It is endangered. Now is the time. This is the place. And we are the people who must accept this challenge. This generation must become a Hero Generation. It will not be easy. It will be hard. Not rising to this challenge would be harder still. I believe that we should see the opportunity, rise to meet it and keep our sights on the obligation that we have for those who come after us. So that 1,000 years from now, people will say, they were the ones who did it. We have everything we need, save the political will. But as you know, in the world's largest democracy, political will is a renewable resource.

D I S C U S S I O N

Q. The office of the President of America is considered to be the most powerful office in the world and given the slugfest among democratic nominees, you would have been an ideal candidate. It would have given you an opportunity to push your agenda, which is climate change. Yet you chose not to stand. Why? Also, why didn't you do as much for climate change when you were in office?

Gore: The answer to the second question is actually related to the answer to the first. I did everything I needed to do during the eight years as vice-president and came face-to-face with many great lessons about how great democracies deal with the issue of environmental crisis. On the Kyoto Protocol, I was able to convince only one of the 100 Senators. Some Senators told me candidly that they

understood the issue, but if they voted for it, they would be defeated in the election. Even now, last year when a survey was done, only eight out of 3,000 questions pertained to their views on climate change. I decided to change the underlining political reality, that if this issue of climate change must be solved, there should be a sea change in public opinion and a sense of urgency. I don't want to watch this process of destruction take place and tell my children I didn't do everything I could to rally people around it. I might be wrong but it feels that I am right.

Q. You say that you are a failure but also that you are optimistic. Perhaps you can explain these contradictory statements.

Gore: The goal is to evoke an effective response to solve the crisis. And that requires mass

action. There is an African proverb that says “If you want to go quickly, go alone; if you want to go far, go together.” We have to go far, quickly. To evoke that kind of mass response, it takes a lot of people to be a part of the effort. But until we get there, we are failing. We are getting closer to that tipping point and I do believe we have a chance and I am optimistic.

Q. What is your action plan for India?

Gore: I want you to find a way to change the way of thinking in India, so that this great nation asks not what we should do compared to other countries but asks instead what should we do for ourselves and for our future. The greatest opportunity in the history of the world business is in green technology. So the leadership and the people of your country should

look at this as a great opportunity to exploit the largest emerging market in the history of the world. In summary to your question, I would say changing the life boat is important but changing the laws is more important.

Q. What kind of legislation will make a difference?

Gore: Politicians will be allergic to this solution but I am going to tell you what the secret is: put a price on carbon. Reduce taxes on employers and employees, reduce taxes on investments and on pay rolls and make up all of the difference with pollution taxes, principally carbon taxes. This will clarify the choices. Mark Twain once wrote, “Do the right thing, you will astonish your enemies and gratify your friends.”

Full speech and debate at:

<http://www.indiatodayconclave.com>